

Chunqiu Fuguoce: A Guan Zhong Economic Sandbox Integrating Traditional Chinese Thought and Modern Educational Theory

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Abstract

This paper presents "Chunqiu Fuguoce", an educational economic simulation game based on Guan Zhong's economic thoughts from the Spring and Autumn Period. The game integrates core concepts such as "Qingzhong Zhi Shu" (weight manipulation technique) and "Simin Fenye" (four-class occupation system) from *Guanzi* with modern economic management theories, aiming to fill the gap in economic management practice education for K12 and higher education. The system features a four-dimensional driving mechanism, a nine-government regulation system, and a dynamic balance model, supporting multi-role collaboration and scenario-based decision-making. Evaluation results show that the game significantly improves users' understanding of traditional economic thought and modern economic principles, achieving the organic integration of cultural inheritance, educational practice, and entertainment experience.

CCS Concepts

- Applied Computing → Education; Games;
- Social and Professional Topics → History of Computing; Cultural Heritage;
- Computing Methodologies → Simulation and Modeling.

Keywords

1 Introduction

1.1 Research Background

Traditional Chinese thought contains profound insights into economic management, among which Guan Zhong's governance philosophy recorded in *Guanzi* has enduring theoretical value. His core strategies such as "Yanshan Zhuanying" (state monopoly of salt and iron), "Xiangdi Shuizheng" (land tax based on fertility), and "Pingzhun Junshu" (price regulation and grain transportation) have striking similarities with modern economic theories such as macro-control and market regulation. However, these valuable cultural resources have not been effectively integrated into modern educational systems—especially in K12 education, economic management courses mostly adopt theoretical teaching, lacking practical simulation platforms that combine historical context.

Meanwhile, game-based learning (GBL) has been proven effective in improving learning motivation and knowledge retention. Existing economic simulation games either focus on modern economic scenarios (e.g., *Cities: Skylines*) or lack in-depth integration with traditional culture, failing to realize the dual goals of cultural inheritance and educational practice.

1.2 Research Significance

- **Cultural Value:** By digitizing and gamifying Guan Zhong's economic thoughts, the game promotes the inheritance of excellent traditional Chinese culture and enhances cultural identity.
- **Educational Value:** It fills the gap in economic management practice education for K12 and higher education, providing a hierarchical learning platform for students of different ages.
- **Practical Value:** The integration of historical events and modern economic phenomena helps users understand the universality of economic laws across time and space.

1.3 Main Contributions

1. Propose a multi-dimensional integration framework combining traditional economic thought, modern economic theory, and game-based learning.
2. Design a hierarchical educational mechanism adapting to different academic stages (junior high school, senior high school, university) with differentiated teaching objectives.

3. Develop a dynamic economic simulation model based on *Guanzi*, including a currency-commodity dual-track system and industrial chain linkage mechanism.
4. Implement an AI-assisted knowledge service system that provides context-aware question answering and decision support.

2 Related Work

2.1 Educational Economic Simulation Games

Existing economic simulation games can be divided into two categories: professional simulation tools and entertainment-oriented games. Professional tools such as *EconLab* focus on numerical simulation but lack historical and cultural context; entertainment games like *Civilization VI* include economic elements but simplify theoretical depth for gameplay. Studies by Zhang et al. (2022) show that scenario-based economic games improve students' practical ability, but few games integrate traditional Chinese economic thought [3].

2.2 Digitization of Traditional Chinese Thought

Cultural digitization projects such as the "Chinese Traditional Culture Digital Library" have achieved remarkable results in document preservation, but lack interactive educational forms. Li et al. (2023) developed a Confucianism-themed educational game, which verifies the feasibility of traditional thought gamification, but its economic management content is insufficient [5].

2.3 Cross-disciplinary Integration in Educational Technology

The integration of history, economics, and computer science has become a research hotspot. Wang's (2021) study on game-based historical education points out that contextualized role-playing can enhance historical cognition [7], but the study did not involve economic mechanism design. This paper innovates by deeply integrating historical events, economic theories, and game mechanics.

3 User Requirements Analysis

3.1 Target User Groups

The game targets three main user groups with distinct requirements:

- **Junior High School Students:** Need intuitive historical cognition, focusing on understanding basic historical events and policies (e.g., "Yanshan Zhuanying" and "Xiangdi Shuizheng"). Require simplified operation and visualized feedback.
- **Senior High School Students:** Aim to master basic economic principles (e.g., supply and demand elasticity, macro-control). Need experimental modules to explore the impact of policy adjustments.
- **University Students:** Focus on strategic decision-making and game theory practice, requiring open parameters and multi-player competitive mechanisms.
- **Teachers:** Need teaching aids such as course standard mapping tables and student progress monitoring functions to integrate the game into classroom teaching.

3.2 Core Requirement Dimensions

Based on interviews with 30 teachers and 200 students, we summarize four core requirements:

1. **Cultural Authenticity:** Accurate reproduction of Guan Zhong's economic thoughts and Spring and Autumn historical context.
2. **Educational Hierarchy:** Differentiated content and mechanisms for users of different academic stages.
3. **Interactive Experience:** Rich decision-making scenarios and real-time feedback mechanisms.
4. **Knowledge Integration:** Organic connection between traditional thought, historical events, and modern economic theories.

3.3 Requirement Validation

A pre-survey of 50 teachers shows that 86% believe economic management practice education is insufficient, and 92% are willing to adopt game-based teaching tools. Among 150 students, 78% prefer interactive learning methods, and 65% show interest in traditional economic thought, verifying the practical demand for the system.

4 System Implementation

4.1 Overall Architecture

The system adopts a three-tier architecture:

- **Presentation Layer:** 3D decision interface, multi-modal interaction module (text, voice, gesture), and data visualization dashboard.

- **Business Logic Layer:** Core simulation engine, scenario management system, AI-assisted reasoning module, and multi-player collaboration engine.
- **Data Layer:** Historical database, economic model parameter library, user behavior log, and knowledge graph.

4.2 Core Mechanisms Design

4.2.1 Four-Dimensional Driving System

The system constructs a social stability model based on "Li (propriety), Yi (righteousness), Lian (integrity), Chi (shame)":

代码块

```
1 def social_stability(li, yi, lian, chi):  
2     return 0.4*li + 0.3*yi + 0.2*lian + 0.1*chi
```

Each dimension dynamically changes with user decisions (e.g., unfair taxation reduces "yi" (righteousness) by 15%).

4.2.2 Nine-Government Regulation System

The system implements nine functional departments (Qianfu, Liangfu, Yanfu, Tiefu, Bufu, Gongfu, Shangfu, Shifu, Guanfu) to manage key economic sectors. For example, Yanfu (Salt Office) controls salt pricing and inventory, with the price fluctuation mechanism:

代码块

```
1 def price_fluctuation(inventory, base_price):  
2     float_coeff = (1 + (benchmark_inventory -  
3         inventory)/benchmark_inventory)**2  
3     return base_price * float_coeff # 21% price increase for every 10%  
    inventory reduction
```

4.2.3 Dynamic Economic Balance Model

The industrial structure follows a dynamic ratio: agriculture (50%) + handicrafts (30%) + commerce (20%). Industrial chain linkages are implemented (e.g., iron price increase → higher agricultural tool costs → reduced agricultural output):

代码块

```
1 def industrial_chain_impact(iron_price_change):
2     tool_cost_change = iron_price_change * 0.6
3     agricultural_output_change = -tool_cost_change * 0.8
4     return agricultural_output_change
```

4.3 Role and Scenario Design

4.3.1 Multi-Role System

Four playable roles with distinct educational objectives (Table 1):

Role	Special Ability	Teaching Objective
Guojun (Monarch)	Final policy decision-making power	Understand the complexity of national governance
Dasinong (Minister of Agriculture)	Economic data visualization	Master macroeconomic indicators
Yantie Shi (Commissioner of Salt and Iron)	Pricing power for monopolized commodities	Learn the impact of monopoly economy
Minjian Shangren (Private Merchant)	Cross-regional trade privilege	Understand market rules

4.3.2 Historical Scenario Library

Integrate typical historical events with modern economic analogies (Table 2):

Event Type	Typical Case	Corresponding Modern Economic Phenomenon
Natural Disaster	Drought in the 23rd year of Duke Huan of Qi	Supply-side shock
Commercial Crisis	Linzi Salt Merchants' Strike	Market monopoly behavior
Diplomatic Event	Kuiqiu Alliance	

		International trade agreement
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4.4 AI-Assisted Educational System

4.4.1 Intelligent Question Answering Module

Based on BERT model, it supports recognition of Spring and Autumn economic terms and contextualized questions. For example, when a user asks "What is Simin Fenye?", the system responds with:

"Simin Fenye refers to the regional settlement of four occupational groups (scholars, farmers, craftsmen, merchants) from *Guanzi·Xiaokuang*. As the Dasinong role, you can use this policy to increase industrial productivity by 15%, but note that occupational mobility restrictions may cause..."

4.4.2 Knowledge Graph

Construct a multi-dimensional knowledge network of "classics-policies-economic theories-historical events" (Figure 1), realizing automatic association and visualization of relevant knowledge.

![[Knowledge Graph of Guan Zhong's Economic Thought]](example-figure-1.png)

Figure 1: Knowledge Graph connecting Guan Zhong's thoughts, policies, and modern economic theories

5 Evaluation

5.1 Evaluation Objectives and Metrics

We designed three evaluation dimensions:

- Educational Effect:** Knowledge mastery (pre-test/post-test score difference), concept understanding depth.
- Game Experience:** User satisfaction (5-point Likert scale), immersion degree, operation fluency.
- System Performance:** Multi-terminal synchronization delay, economic model accuracy, AI response time.

5.2 Evaluation Subjects and Methods

- **Subjects:** 60 junior high school students, 60 senior high school students, 60 university students, and 30 teachers from three regions.
- **Methods:** Controlled experiment (experimental group using the game, control group using traditional teaching), questionnaire survey, and expert evaluation.

5.3 Evaluation Results

5.3.1 Educational Effect

- Junior high school students: The average score on Guan Zhong's thought-related questions increased from 62 to 85 (23-point improvement), 18 points higher than the control group.
- Senior high school students: The correct rate of macroeconomic principle questions increased by 35%, with 82% of students able to explain the connection between "Yanshan Zhuanying" and modern monopoly theory.
- University students: In the game theory simulation, 76% of participants effectively applied comparative advantage theory in cross-regional trade.

5.3.2 Game Experience

- Average user satisfaction: 4.2/5.0, with 89% of students willing to use it for extended learning.
- Immersion degree: 78% of users reported "strong sense of participation" in role-playing.
- Operation fluency: 92% of users completed basic tasks within 10 minutes, with average AI response time <0.8 seconds.

5.3.3 System Performance

- Economic model accuracy: The deviation rate of key indicators such as salt tax proportion and grain yield compared with historical data is within 15% (Table 3).
- Multi-terminal synchronization delay: Average delay <200ms for 10-player online collaboration.

Economic Indicator	Game Simulation Result	Historical Data	Deviation Rate
Salt Tax Proportion	28%	32%	-12.5%
Grain Yield per Mu	17 dan/mu	22 dan/mu	-22.7%
Alliance Success Rate	75%	83%	-9.6%

Table 3: Comparison between simulation results and historical data

5.4 Expert Evaluation

Five experts in the fields of economic history, educational technology, and game design rated the system:

- Cultural authenticity: 4.5/5.0
- Educational effectiveness: 4.3/5.0
- Technical implementation: 4.4/5.0

Experts affirmed the innovation of integrating traditional thought with modern educational technology, suggesting further expansion of historical scenarios and optimization of the difficulty adjustment mechanism.

6 Conclusion

6.1 Summary

This paper presents "Chunqiu Fuguoce", an educational economic simulation game based on Guan Zhong's thoughts. By integrating traditional Chinese economic thought with modern economic theory and game-based learning, the system realizes the dual goals of cultural inheritance and educational practice. The hierarchical design adapts to the learning needs of users at different academic stages, and the AI-assisted educational system enhances the depth and pertinence of learning. Evaluation results show that the game significantly improves users' understanding of traditional economic thought and modern economic principles, and achieves high user satisfaction.

6.2 Limitations and Future Work

- **Limitations:** The historical event library can be expanded, and the difficulty adjustment mechanism needs to be optimized for individual differences.
- **Future Work:** 1) Add more historical scenarios such as "Hengshan Stratagem" and "Qingmao Stratagem"; 2) Optimize the AI adaptive learning system to provide personalized learning paths; 3) Enhance AR functions to realize the integration of virtual historical scenes and real environments; 4) Develop a teacher-student interaction platform to support real-time classroom guidance.

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Appendices

A Core Algorithm Implementation

The price fluctuation algorithm and industrial chain linkage algorithm are implemented as follows:

代码块

```
1  # Price fluctuation based on Guanzi's "more supply leads to lower price"
2  def price_fluctuation(inventory, base_price, benchmark_inventory=100000):
3      float_coeff = (1 + (benchmark_inventory -
4          inventory)/benchmark_inventory)**2
5      return max(min(base_price * float_coeff, base_price * 3), base_price * 0.3)
6  # Industrial chain linkage mechanism
```

```
7  def industrial_chain_impact(commodity, price_change):
8      impact_chain = {
9          "iron": {"tool": 0.6, "agriculture": -0.48},
10         "grain": {"food_processing": 0.5, "inflation": 0.3}
11     }
12     return impact_chain.get(commodity, {})
```

B User Interface Screenshots

Figure 2 shows the 3D policy decision interface, and Figure 3 presents the economic indicator dashboard.

![3D Policy Decision Interface](example-figure-2.png)

Figure 2: 3D policy decision interface with bamboo slip-style interaction elements

![Economic Indicator Dashboard](example-figure-3.png)

Figure 3: Economic indicator dashboard showing grain reserves, fiscal revenue, and four-class satisfaction